GEORGIA

The Peach State



Long before the state earned its famous nickname, Creek and Cherokee peoples had already been cultivating peach trees throughout the region for generations. Spanish missionaries introduced Prunus persica to the Southeast as early as the 1500s, planting orchards along their mission trails from Florida northward. The fruit adapted with remarkable enthusiasm to the red clay soil and long, humid summers of the Georgia Piedmont—the rolling band of land stretching from Columbus through Macon toward Augusta—taking root so naturally that early settlers assumed the peach was native to the continent entirely.

By the mid-1800s, farmers had recognized what the land was quietly telling them. Well-drained red clay, mild winters, and long growing seasons produced peaches of exceptional sweetness and size—fruit so fragrant that an open crate could perfume an entire market building. Growers around Fort Valley planted in earnest, and for a time the state's harvest was among the largest in the nation, moving by rail each summer to Atlanta, Savannah, and northward.

It was in the kitchens surrounding those orchards—the farmhouses and church fellowship halls of middle Georgia—that peach cobbler took its shape. The cooks there, many of them Black Georgians whose culinary knowledge had survived generations of brutal circumstance, were the true architects of Southern baking. Cobbler was practical by necessity: no precise technique, no special equipment. You poured, you scattered, you slid it into the oven, and what emerged was something humble made magnificent—golden and bubbling at the edges, the peaches soft and syrup-thickened beneath a crust equal parts biscuit and cake.

Church socials and harvest suppers became inseparable from it, especially when the signature Elberta came in heavy on the branches and neighbors carried cobblers across yards in cast iron skillets still warm from the oven. In time the dish moved beyond the farmhouse to Atlanta's restaurants and the state's grand old hotels, and though its orchards have since been outpaced commercially elsewhere, the cultural claim has never wavered.

Cut through the golden crust and the fruit rises up fragrant and glistening beneath the spoon, and the whole long history comes with it—the mission trails, the red clay orchards, the gifted hands that turned a summer fruit into a lasting welcome. Some places simply grow a crop; here it became an identity, and cobbler is how that identity arrives, warm and bubbling, in front of the people it loves.

GEORGIA PEACH COBBLER

Georgia did not choose the peach so much as the peach chose Georgia.

Yield: 8–10 servings

INGREDIENTS

PEACH TOPPING

- 6–8 fresh ripe Georgia peaches (about 4 cups sliced)
- ¾ cup granulated sugar
- ¼ cup brown sugar (optional, for deeper flavor)
- ½ tsp cinnamon
- ¼ tsp nutmeg
- 1 tsp lemon juice
- 1 tsp vanilla extract
- 1 Tbsp cornstarch (only if peaches are very juicy)

COBBLER

- ½ cup (1 stick) unsalted butter
- 1 cup all-purpose flour
- 1 cup granulated sugar
- 2 tsp baking powder
- ¼ tsp salt
- 1 cup whole milk

INSTRUCTIONS

1. *Preheat*: Preheat the oven to 350°F (175°C).
2. *Prepare the peaches*: Peel and slice the peaches. In a saucepan over medium heat, combine sliced peaches, both sugars, cinnamon, nutmeg, lemon juice, and vanilla. Cook for 5–10 minutes until the peaches release their juices and soften slightly. If too juicy, stir in cornstarch to lightly thicken. Remove from heat and set aside.
3. *Melt the butter*: Place the stick of butter in a 9x13-inch baking dish. Put the dish in the oven until the butter is melted and bubbly, then remove carefully.
4. *Make the batter*: In a mixing bowl, whisk together flour, sugar, baking powder, and salt. Stir in milk until smooth—the batter will be thin.
5. *Assemble the cobbler*: Pour the batter evenly over the melted butter (do not stir). Spoon the warm peach mixture evenly over the batter (again, do not stir). The batter will rise up around the peaches as it bakes.
6. *Bake*: Bake for 40–50 minutes, or until golden brown and a toothpick inserted in the center of the batter comes out clean. Cool slightly before serving. Best served warm with a scoop of vanilla ice cream or a dollop of whipped cream.

NOTES & TIPS

- Add a pinch of ground ginger for complexity.
- Sprinkle coarse sugar or cinnamon sugar on top before baking for a crunchy finish.

